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Harold Ousley

Saxophonist Harold Ousley was born in Chicago on January 23, 1929. He has performed and recorded with Count Basie, Dinah Washington, Machito and Brother Jack McDuff. Harold is a prolific songwriter and is currently active with the Jazz Mobile and productions for cable television

Harold was interviewed in New York City on January 12, 2001, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are filming in New York City for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. I'm quite pleased to have Harold Ousley with me this morning. Thank you for getting up so early.

HO: It's a pleasure to be here.

MR: And making the trip in.

HO: Thank you for inviting me.

MR: We had a kind of fortuitous meeting in the lobby last night to make this happen.

HO: Yeah. So many wonderful things going on here.

MR: Yeah. You've had quite a varied career in your life. And when you grew up in Chicago, the music at that time, you kind of grew up right in the midst of the swing and hot jazz era.

HO: Yeah. Well when I was coming up, they used to have, even in grammar school I used to go out to the jam sessions, and sometimes I'd be out there until one o'clock in the morning and I'd have to be at school the next day. Well not grammar school but high school. The next day I would have to be in school class at eight o'clock. But there were so many wonderful things going on, a lot of wonderful musicians playing at just various places. And at the time the music was centered in around 35th Street in Chicago. This is where Grand Terrace was. I found out that through the years the music tended, and I don't know whether this happened in other cities but it seems like every ten years it moved up, like it was on 35th Street, then 43rd Street would be the jazz activity place, the clubs were in that area. And then from there it moved to 51st Street, 55th Street, and out to 63rd. They used to have a, oh I'm trying to think, this club will come to me, but there was a club in Chicago. They used to have what they called a breakfast dance on Mondays. Now the clubs would open at ten o'clock. If you worked in a club you worked from ten to four. And what would happen, like on a Sunday night, at four o'clock, all the club owners, the musicians and everybody would go out to this particular club.

MR: Was that the Club DeLisa by any chance?

HO: DeLisa. That's what I'm thinking. And Red Saunders had the band out there at that time. And they started their breakfast dance at about four or five in the morning. Red would play a dance set at five, from five to six. And then take an intermission. And then they'd start the show about seven o'clock in the morning, with chorus girls you know, and Joe Williams was out there at the time. In fact that's how, when he was working there, when Basie — because everybody that came in town would go out to the DeLisa. And then at eight o'clock, a particular club owner would go back to his club and open up, and then everyone would come there, and he would have a band for that morning, and then you'd just jam from that time until you just fell out or went home or whatever. In fact there would be musicians who, if they might not have been out on a Sunday, they'd get up on Monday afternoon and come to the session and they would play until, you know, whatever time. And then at ten o'clock at night you had the regular Monday night band. So you had music going on from ten o'clock Sunday night 'till four o'clock Tuesday morning. It was really something.

MR: That's amazing.

HO: But it was wonderful. Because you know you'd run into — it would be similar to like here. You never know who you're going to run into. And Johnny Griffin used to play down to one of the clubs, The Flame they called it. And the bandstand was so small. They had a little board across the bar. And we'd be leaning over the bandstand. You know but everybody had a great time.

MR: That's funny. I guess that was a good training ground too for young musicians.

HO: It was. Because you got a chance to hear everybody. Because even if you didn't get a chance to hear musicians in some of the clubs. Because they had — even on the west side, they had — in fact Yusef Lateef used to play at a club on the west side. You know but on a Monday you would see all the musicians like this because everybody would hang out for gigs and just hear everybody else that played.

MR: So this was what years in particular for you?

HO: Well this was, let's see, I left for New York in '57. DeLisa was happening in '55, '54, well even before then but in the '40s and '50s. Late '40s and '50s.

MR: What was that scene like racially? Was it fully segregated or —

HO: Well yeah, in certain areas. Now where the jazz was played, and that was well let's see 39th Street was where The Flame was. Yeah, because at that time the music had moved from 35th Street up now to around 39th Street and 43rd. And of course you know at the DeLisa and at the clubs it was black and white. But maybe on the north side or the west side, depending on where the area was, there was segregation.

MR: Was there a separate blues scene also at that time?

HO: Yeah. There was a club on 47th Street. I think at the Club 409. The people like Muddy Water, Sunnyland Slim, used to work there. I'd go by there and hear everybody. In fact I worked with Sunnyland and Memphis Slim, Roosevelt Sykes. Because in Chicago a lot of times if musicians wanted to work regular you had to work with blues groups, you know what I mean. So I got the opportunity, which was very good, because you add to your repertoire and your ability. And of course the blues is one of the centerpieces of the music. And the thing about the blues is everybody knows about the blues. Because if you live you've had the blues at some time and we can appreciate it, plus the blues is a music that can help you feel better, you can get rid of — it's therapeutic you know. So it's really one of the staple pieces and it's important to be able to appreciate it and get into it.

MR: Good statement. Probably you ran into circumstances playing in some new keys I would imagine, if you started playing with guitar players?

HO: Oh yeah. Well during this time in Chicago there were musicians there who, when you go to a session, they would go through the keys. Especially if they stayed home and practiced and this was their thing. I remember there was a piano player there and he played saxophone and piano. And he liked to play up here. When he got on the bandstand, you had to be ready to play up here in whatever key he played in. So it was a place where you know if you went to a session you had to really prepare. And if you didn't, you know you'd have to go home in the woodshed. So in that sense it was important to do. But then there was a lot of love too. A musician would say, a lot of times, you know if they saw you were struggling they would come and say well you should play big, play through all the keys, learn all the tunes or whatever. So it was very helpful. So there was some love there as well as competition.

MR: You had a pretty good experience in school? With school music when you grew up?

HO: Yeah, well I started music in high school. What happened, I went to Willard Grammar School, and before we went to high school when we were in eighth grade they sent over, the high school, DuSable, sent over applications to ask what — to let you know what subject they had and find out what subjects you wanted to be in. And so I got into band because prior to that, when I was in grammar school, I used to take piano. Because my mother gave me — my grandmother gave me piano lessons. Because at that time, to play piano, because people had pianos in their home it was just the thing to play piano. And I had people in my family who were in there — I had my uncle who was a tap dancer and my mother was interested in show business for a while. So there was a love for the music. And so by me taking piano and even though I didn't stay with it, because at that time I had more of an interest in going out playing football and pump pump pullaway with it, with the fellas in the neighborhood. And so at this time I took music. And my uncle, I had an uncle who didn't play music, he was into sports, but he loved jazz. So he used to play

all the big band things, the records for me, at the time. And so that's when I first heard the saxophone. Of course I fell in love with it. So going to high school I wanted to get in the band and learn how to play saxophone. And Walter Dyett, a very wonderful teacher who taught Gene Ammons and Nat King Cole and people like this. First if you were going to play saxophone you had to play clarinet. And the reason for this is that a clarinet has three registers. And within it it has a saxophone register. So if you play clarinet you automatically know how to finger the saxophone, you got a head start. Whereas if you play saxophone, you know, playing the clarinet is another situation. So in first and second, in beginner's band and first and second band, we played clarinet. And then we had a concert band, I was in the clarinet section there. But we had what he called a booster band. It was a swing band. And in there was the preparation for being able to go into a professional band. And so the reading ability and everything, in fact Johnny Griffin joined Lionel Hampton's band when he was in school. He was 16 at that time. But he was ready to, you know because Cap prepared us in that.

MR: This was really then kind of serious preparation for a career, is that right?

HO: Yes it was. You know I didn't realize until years later, just how much knowledge and ability that Captain Dyett had. He used to tell us, "When you play, play to the back of the audience." In other words then we're projecting our sound all the way, so everybody in the middle was going to hear it, but the person in back should hear it as well. And I didn't realize until I started reading metaphysical material just what that was, you know, positive thinking and projecting the mind and things like this. And so he was about this. And the things that he taught was just even though we might not have realized it then, and the thing about it, you weren't officially in the band until you got thrown out at some time. Because everybody in the band got thrown out at some time. Because he would throw you out for some of the just least things, things that you would think why is he throwing me out for that. I remember on one occasion, this was during the wartime, and I had a clarinet and during this time some of the shops where you would go to have your instrument fixed, they didn't have what they needed. I went and the repairman had put some glue because the bottom, the bell, was broken and he had to fix that. So what happened, I'm in the band playing, and when you play it the saliva comes out of your horn and loosened the bell up. And I managed to catch it. Because I knew if it hit the floor, out the door. So I just put it down on the floor. So I'm playing with no bell. But Cap could see everybody in the band and it was almost, it was about 50, 60 musicians in the band, and he looked over there, and so now he came over to me and took my clarinet and said what the so-and-so is this? And everybody fell— he said, "get out of here." I was trying to keep from getting thrown out. But when you come back to him he would

always let you get back in the band because he knew you were serious about wanting to be in the music.

MR: Gee. That's a great story. He's quite a legend I guess.

HO: Yes. He was a beautiful person, plus he had a professional band, some of the musicians would play in the band.

MR: Were the students, did they have a love-hate relationship with him because he was so strict or was it really —

HO: Well no, because most of the students were really like this, I mean they are trying to keep on his good side. Not everybody — everybody gets a different impression and responds to the situation differently. But everybody had respect for him. And so they wanted to be in the band, so if you got thrown out for not paying attention or just fooling around, you would go back to make sure you got in the band. And being in there, it really developed your ability. One of the things, we had a lot of times we would have maybe three saxophone players, tenor players, on one stand. Now everybody wasn't going to be able to play the concert or the assembly, so you had to really have it together, play well, and whatever necessary to be there. Because the least little thing that you didn't do right, he would take you off the stand. Sometimes it might be a couple of tenor players. But you just kept your nose to the grindstone. But it was a wonderful experience. We had what was called "hi-jinx" once a year, during the summer. And the hi-jinx, everybody in school that had talent would participate in the hi-jinx. The application would go around to all of the classes. And if you sang, if you played an instrument or whatever — and of course the booster band played for it. And we'd have a story line. So it was nice, it prepared you for show business, whatever you did, whether you sang or danced or whatever. So it was really great.

MR: Now I read in something that you played for quite a number of years in a circus band.

HO: Yeah, well that was only really not — it was only for one year — in fact not a whole year, for about four or five months. I joined a carnival, Haney Brothers. And I think I joined it in Champaign, Illinois. And of course the carnival plays cities, and usually on the outside or the outskirts of town. And they called that a still date. Because at that time it's only the carnival there and it usually started say about six o'clock in the evening after people get off from work. And they'd come out on the carnival. And we had what we called it was a showboat. And it was supposed to be like a showboat on the Mississippi River. And it was a tent, but in the front we had a ramp you would come up like you would do on a boat. And we would play, we were on the balcony playing, I don't know how many people, about seven people in the band. And then of course we had — the entertainers would be on the bottom deck. And then we had what we called a barker. And what he would do on the midway, say like if a crowd of people are down here, the barker

for that particular show would come out and he'd let the people know what they're going to see. Well as soon as that show let out, if your tent was next then you had to be there to catch those people. And you'd bring them to your site. And of course when they got to us the barker would tell them — and then he would say a lot of things that was not true, like we got the girl that does the dance of the seven veils and she'd drop these veils one by one. Then the girl that does the dance with the balloons or bubbles and you punch — and they were never on the show. And so the carnival is a place usually where the entertainers there are either entertainers that have been in the business a long time but are no longer at the top of the business, they're not working as much, so the carnival offers work, or they're young entertainers like myself trying to get started. So you don't make no money on a still date. The only time you make money is doing the fair dates. That's when you go to the cities where the farmers are selling their livestock and they have auto races, and the carnival is there. So they have a lot of people. And you work pretty hard. Like we would get on the midway at nine o'clock in the morning, and our last show would be at one o'clock in the morning. And so we would end up doing about 25 shows. But the carnival, it was a lot of fun, there was some hardship and a lot of times with no money but there's still a certain something about it. You know like they say the sawdust in your vein kind of thing. There are things about it that you enjoy. But in the case of the carnival that we were at, I guess after I was on there a month, about two months, I said well I'm going to have to get back towards — the money was very short sometimes. So I said well the next time I get train fare, I'm going, I'm leaving. So that's what happened a lot of times. I think I left in Muskogee, Oklahoma. But I traveled around, I saw a lot of things. In fact we had a trumpet player on there named Frank, he played two trumpets at one time. And he used to drink a lot. And so sometimes he'd throw the trumpet up, and a few times he missed it, and his trumpet was all bent up. You know, but it was a lot of fun, there was a lot of love there, and hard times, but it was a mixture of a lot of things. It was a good experience.

MR: I wanted to make sure I understand what you meant by "steal dates." Is that what you said?

HO: Still. S-T-I-L-L dates.

MR: Oh, still dates.

HO: Still date. Well still date probably meant there's not a lot of activity.

MR: Okay.

HO: The carnival, like I say, we would get started about six o'clock in the evening when people would come home from work. But there wouldn't be a lot of people out there. And so we might close down at around ten, just depending on how many people you had. So you didn't make a lot of money. And the Haney Brothers had a train, that we rode on.

But we used to joke about the train, that it was so slow you could get off the train, go to the store, get something to eat, come back and catch it.

MR: Oh, good story.

HO: And again, even on there there was a certain amount of prejudice. Because we were on the last car. But it was really like family. We had the turtle lady on there, the turtle lady, she even had her boyfriend.

MR: Good story. In the late 50s, rock & roll was kind of rearing its head. Did you get into that?

HO: Yeah, I got into that. Well you know I had to play a variety of music a lot of times in order to work. But I've always enjoyed different kinds of music. You know, a variety of music. Because I think all music is good when it's played well, if it has good feeling, and even in performances I do now, I like to do a variety of things, like swing, play pretty, play funky, uptempo. Because people, everybody likes something different. And I think, my belief, in the things that I've studied, I found out that music is a very essential part of life. That life was created to musical principles. Because life has tempo, it has cycles. And everything vibrates, like vibration is tempo. Every atom vibrates. You know we're constantly — there's movement in everything. And the planets, the same way with the planets. And everything is in harmony and in sync with each other. And so everything is really music. When we talk to each other and we get along, music is harmony. When people get along together, that's harmony and it's music. And when people don't get along it's no longer music and harmony. And I think music is — well I think even now, but even to a greater degree in solving situations in the world — music is going to play a major part in that as people come together through the music. Even like here. People are coming together because they love the music. Whether they're teaching it in school or playing it in clubs or whatever they're doing, what brings us together is the music. And we come together in friendship and in love and harmony. So music is an essential thing. And when people get involved in it, they begin to develop a greater harmony. You know like in jazz you find people of all races, of all ages coming together, and enjoying the music and sharing ideas. So I think the more that music, and especially with jazz, jazz is a wonderful venue for that. And usually, people who like jazz have gotten to a level where they want to communicate and get along with people. You never see people going to jazz concert hitting each other in the mouth. You know, it's always about loving the music. You see somebody next to you saying hello, so right away you've got something to talk about and you comment on the music and people have met and fell in love and married. So the music is going to play essential — and not only jazz but all, you know concert music, all music that is serious and the people who are involved in it approach it from a

very positive level and a level of love and concern. It happens. But I think that's going to be a major part of it.

MR: Wow. That's some deep thoughts. That's good. At what point in your life did you really think that I'm going to make a living with this?

HO: Well I guess after I got in the band in high school, then I began to really get serious about it. Because prior to that time, when I was taking piano lessons, I was mainly, I'd go out and play with the fellas around the neighborhood who were not into music. So I tended to want to do whatever they were doing. And then when I got to high school everybody that I was hanging out with were in the band. And we were all going either to jam sessions or we'd be jamming and playing and marching bands. Because the band in school, we played for football games, so we were like the ROTC band. And then we had the competitions, all the high schools in Chicago would have competitions. And a couple of times our school won the competition. And then of course the swing band. But I got all my time, everybody I was around was into music. So that's when I really got involved in it, and wanted to really be a professional musician. And there were so many wonderful musicians to listen to in Chicago. And even in high school I started my own band. We used to play for dances, students in school would have their social clubs. And I had Richard Davis was a bass player in the band at that time. And so at that time I decided.

MR: And what would your song list include for those kinds of gigs?

HO: Well you know my first musical role models and heroes were Gene Ammons and Lester Young, and of course Coleman Hawkins and Charlie Parker as the years went on. But the first people I guess that I really began to relate to was Gene Ammons because he was there in Chicago. And then of course Lester Young was very popular at the time and there was a lot of records out. And so I used to, I think I bought, I think Lester was playing a Conn at the time, and I bought a Conn. And then Gene Ammons was playing, I think he was playing a Brillhart mouthpiece, so I bought a Brillhart mouthpiece, thinking I was going to get the sound. I found out it wasn't the mouthpiece at all. But I used to get a chance to go hear him a lot. So it was a lot of inspiration there. And "D.B. Blues," because at the time Lester Young had a song out called "D.B. Blues," so I learned the solo to "D.B. Blues." Plus you could get girls —

MR: Oh is that right?

HO: You know, yeah. So that was one of the things. And then I learned Gene Ammons "Red Top," because when you were playing if you played those tunes, people who liked jazz liked it, the musicians you know. So that was my first direction. And then I started to listen to a lot of very wonderful saxophones and pianos too. Because I found out that it's important to be flexible, to listen to a lot of things, a lot of people, a lot of music. Because you broaden your own scope and it gives you a lot to draw upon and a lot to appreciate.

And it keeps you from being one dimensional. And so like in jazz it's — musicians, not everybody — but used to sing a lot. Because this was part of — Louis Armstrong, you know, and a lot of musicians, Diz, you know, because this is all because music is entertainment too you know. So you learn how to do a little bit of all of it, and then write songs and different things.

MR: Right. You want to be as valuable a musician as you can.

HO: Yeah. More irons in the fire. This was not working, get something over here.

MR: There you go.

HO: So that's very important from a business standpoint.

MR: It seems like New York was a magnet for almost all musicians. And you went there eventually?

HO: Yeah. Well musicians who had been in New York would come back to Chicago and tell us about all the wonderful things happening in New York, who they saw, and at this particular time, 52nd Street was the street that was going as well as Minton's uptown. And these were the musicians we used to listen to on the records, so we were always, you know, open ears and say well we've got to go to New York. And I finally got the opportunity through a friend of mine, a trumpet player who moved to Cleveland. And there was a band leader, he was a bass player named Duke Jenkins, had a band there and he used to, I think it was the Rose Room he used to play in. But he was well known in Cleveland. And he was getting ready to come to New York so he was forming a bigger band, a ten piece band. And they were having, during this time they had what they called the Big, Big Shows. That was, you saw they had more than one artist on the show. Because prior to that time when you'd go to a concert you'd just see one artist. You know Roy Hamilton was one of the stars, and Billy Williams' quartet. Because they had been on "Toast of the Town" and so they were the stars. And then Jerry Lee Lewis had "Great Balls of Fire," a hit out there. So these were the artists on the show. And we played in Rhode Island and we played in Hartford, Connecticut, and did we play New York? We played in the surrounding area, but this gave me the opportunity to come here to New York. So that's how I got here. And the first place I stayed was at the hotel where Minton's is. And I could hear the music upstairs, so that was heaven. I went down, the first thing I did was went downstairs to hear the music. Because I had been hearing about Minton's. And the next day I went downtown because somebody had told me about a hotel down there that all the musicians lived in, and also, at that time on Broadway everybody used to frequent a couple of — there was a place called The Turf, and it was right next store to Lyndon's, between 49th and 50th on Broadway. So everybody would come in there and you'd meet, because you would run into people and you'd get gigs. Get record dates or what they called demo dates. They used to have demo dates that didn't

pay as much as record dates, but a lot of times you might be able to do five or six demo dates in a day so that was, you know, good money. So you would go in from one bar to another and see who you could find. It was like a networking, like here you just went around to see, you know, no telling who you might run into. But everybody used to go to The Turf or either there was Beefsteak Charlie's. Now Beefsteak Charlie's was the place where Milt Hinton and a lot of the musicians who were playing a lot of the better gigs, you know at Jim and Andy's, who were on the record dates. So if you wanted to get into that, you know to meet someone, then you would go there. And at Beefsteak Charlie's, Hawk — I used to see Coleman Hawkins, a lot of musicians, like a lot of the older musicians as well as the younger musicians would come in there, because you'd see these musicians and then you'd get gigs and demos and whatever was happening. But it was always a good place, and Papa Jo would be there. And so you know that was a great time during this time. And I lived at — the hotel they had told me about was The Flanders. And that was, they had two entrances, between 48th Street, they had a 48th Street entrance, and 47th Street. And all the musicians, whoever's band you were in would stay there because the rent was economical. At that time I think you could get a room for $15, room and bath for $18. And plus you were right there at Times Square, the automat was open and you could go to the automat and you could get a meal for 50 cents, a dollar, a dollar and a quarter. And then you could sit up front in the window and you're looking out on Broadway. And then you'd go three blocks up and that's where The Turf was. And you'd go to 51st Street around to where Beefsteak Charlie's was, and you'd go down to 52nd Street, there's where Jim and Andy's was. So people would be going back and forth. And then they had, like in the Brill Building and a couple of other buildings centered in that area, they would have the little small studios. That's where you would go and do the demos. And the purpose of the demo was say for an artist who might not have had money to go in the studio, but he could go and do a demo date, and like if he had an agent, the agent would get a demo done on him. And they'd get the musician, and everybody saving money, but at the same time they're making money but the artist gets a chance maybe to take his demo now to the record label. So it was a lot of activity like that going on.

MR: That's interesting. I mean they're still doing similar stuff today, with people shopping their wares, but this would be something you'd go in, and — how did the music actually come together for those things that quickly?

HO: Well usually it depended. Sometimes you would have to read, or maybe the singer didn't have any music. So the piano player would know — maybe the piano player would be somebody that he knew and had rehearsed with, he would know what the chords was but it would be a standard tune, or either you would learn it right away. And you would have to be able to do that to be able to do the demo date. But those things usually worked out.

And a lot of times with demo dates, you didn't have to necessarily be a reader all the time, it just depended on what was needed. Because they might want somebody to play a great solo behind a person or just somebody to put background music or play whatever parts. Each demo called for a different thing. But you would get to know somebody who did a lot of demo dates, so they would put you on demo dates. So you would know two or three people so you could make some good money, pay the rent and buy — you know. So it was a way of making a living and being in music and getting the opportunity to do other things.

MR: What would a typical demo date pay, and how long did they take usually?

HO: Well sometimes during this time a demo date might be 20, 25 dollars, it might even be 15 dollars. But if you — your hotel rent is due, you know what I mean, and you're not working, that's 15 dollars you've got to work with. You know what I mean? And sometimes the musicians had to deliver sandwiches during the day or if you'd find another — you know where there's a will there's a way. But the main thing you're here in New York. And as long as you are out there, you got a chance to, there's an opportunity of being in the right place at the right time. And then you're constantly woodshedding. And at that time they used to have sessions at Small's Paradise up in Harlem. And there was a little place called Connie's. And I would take the subway train up to Small's and the jam sessions usually started around ten, ten to two, and maybe I could go up there for two hours. And then they had jam sessions in Brooklyn. And at the time, well they had the Baby Grand, but there was a club, The Continental, it was a club in Brooklyn where Bud Powell used to play. So I had, when I got in New York naturally I sought out where all the places were. So I'd get on the subway train and sometimes people would drive in the car and by the time they'd get to The Continental, I'm there already. You'd look up, you know, but at that time that's what you had — you tried to be everywhere necessary. And then down at the Village they had the Five Spot and they had the Club Bohemia, you know and I would go down there at the time Randy Weston was down there and he worked, in fact they had music seven nights a week, I think Randy worked six and on Monday nights they had off night groups. And there was just a lot of great music playing. And so you'd get a chance to hear a lot of music, plus you got exposed. And during that time record companies, if they heard somebody new was in town from somebody they knew like maybe somebody playing for the label would say oh so-and-so is a great trumpet player, you ought to hear him. They came out the clubs to listen to see who was in town and a lot of times that's how musicians got on the recordings. You know that doesn't happen like that now, it's on another level. But at that time you know you might be sitting in at a club and in the audience was somebody from a record company was there and you got a date.

MR: Wow. And this was about what time period?

HO: This was, I came here in '57.

MR: Wow that's interesting. I thought that intense scene had died out, so I'm interested to hear that.

HO: No, Birdland was still open then. Like I said clubs in the Village were open. They had three or four clubs in the village and they still had activity in Brooklyn and uptown was still going. As a matter of fact Sugar Ray's was open — Sugar Ray, the boxer had a club. And Seventh Avenue at that time, they had four or five clubs. You could, you know — because Sugar Ray's, well he was at 21st Street and a place called Red Randolph's which was right across the street from there, and then 125th Street, they had something, then you go onto 135th Street you know. And then at that time you could just walk around, you know you could walk from 21st Street all the way up to 25th and 35th Street. And people would be hanging out and they would go by Wells — there was a place called Wells — it was right next to the Count Basie's, and they had the greatest waffles and chicken. And everybody would come from downtown and after they leave the club go for chicken and waffles. And they'd meet in the morning and talk you know. But that — and then there were different after hour clubs if you knew where they were, and people would go and play. Then of course Birdland was open. And everybody would go down to Birdland, especially on Monday night. Because they had a section in Birdland, you could come in and you didn't have to drink, you could just sit in that section and listen to the music, or you could go to the bar, or you could sit in a booth. And of course everybody — Sarah Vaughan, Miles, you know, everybody on a Monday night that was in town would be down to Birdland because that was the hang out. It was really great.

MR: Yeah. You make it sound great. Like there was a real fraternity between the musicians.

HO: Yeah.

MR: Whew. So your first recording opportunity —

HO: That was with Bethlehem Records. And this was in '60. And I'm trying to think, did I — I recorded when I came back from Europe. Because I went to Paris, I was on a show which was more or less like a rock & roll show, "Festival of Songs." And they had Jay and the Americans.

MR: Jay and the Americans.

HO: Jay and the Americans was one of the headlining groups, and I was with a group called Ray Scott, he was a singer, and we had a girl drummer. And the show toured in Italy on the coastline, all of the resorts down the coast line, Viareggio, we even went to Rome. Then after we left there we ended up in France and — oh right now the name escapes me, but it's one of the places where they have the festivals in the south of France. And after then I think — oh we ended up in Paris, because we played Salle Pleyel, and they gave

me a chance to get to Paris. So I left, well the show ended there and I stayed in Paris and I lived over in Montmarte. And I used to take the — well they call it the metro there. So I learned how to use the metro and you'd get all over Paris. And the great thing about the metro, if you knew where you were going you could find it very easily. And so I would go over to the Left Bank. In fact the club I worked in was a club called oh, Le Chat qui Peche, which means a cat with fishes. And the lady who owned the club was Madame Ricard. She used to smoke a cigar all the time. And she was one of the freedom fighters during the war. And where we played was down in the basement. And I think maybe at that time during the war there was maybe like a secret place that they utilized. But this was a cave where the music was. And because when I first came to Paris I heard about, they told me about the Chat qui Peche. And I went over there, a friend of mine, J.T. Hogan, a drummer, was working there. He had a band. And so I sat in and played, and he hired me. And at that time Alice Coltrane, who was not Coltrane then, she was married to a singer, Poncho [Kenny] Hagood, who used to work with Diz. And she was, they were living in Paris. She was a piano player there, and then when Clark Terry came over with Duke to join Free and Easy, which was a show that Quincy Jones had written, and that was a band full of stars man, everybody you can think of was in there. So it was like old home week. Because everybody used to meet. There was a place called Gabby and Haynes. And I forget — Gabby, I think that was a woman, and Haynes was a man. But he was a cook and he was from the United States. And it was a mixed couple. But their cooking, you could get greens, you could get all the home cooking. So everybody used to come there and meet and eat and drink. But it was just great. It was a good time to be there. When Clark joined Free and Easy and left the show, he came to work at the Chat qui Peche. And he and I worked together. And so it was a very good — when I came back, that's when I did the Bethlehem recording. Because on the cover I had on a French tam and they had the setting like in France. Because over there they had, with the advertisements, they have a sort of cylindrical thing that they put the advertisement on.

MR: Oh, yes, right.

HO: So they had this kind of a thing on the cover, but it wasn't a real thing. I had to pretend like I was learning up against it because if I leaned it would fall over, just a piece of cardboard. But that was because I had just came back. But that was the first recording. I'm sorry to make this so long.

MR: No, that's interesting. You seem to have been in the right places at the right time, as far as the kind of intense activity.

HO: Yeah. I've had some good experiences. But I feel that in life, I think we all, number one, are here for a purpose. It's not just being here. So there are certain experiences for us to have that help to fulfill us, help us to grow, give us understanding, patience. A lot of the

things that we need as individuals. And I think, I believe in karma. I think our karma takes us to those experiences that we need. If it's music that we're trying to excel at, or if it's writing, or whatever it is, we come in contact with people who help us to develop that, who inspire us or who can give us the information, or whatever, to help to take us to that next level. And so we play an important part in their lives and they play an important part in ours. So we are taken to all of those experiences that we need, that are important for us, to take us to that next experience. So like our being here together, we didn't know each other before.

MR: I know. I would have to agree with that.

HO: But experience has brought us — experience has brought everybody to this point, where we are because of the interest in music, and what we are trying to do next. And it's in one way or another we are helping each other with that program, because it's all about networking.

MR: Yeah. I liked what you just said, very nice. Because you've told me things today already that I wasn't sure of and that I hadn't heard before. So it was kind of a fortuitous meeting that we just met last night.

HO: Well this is what propels me in my life — to feel that there is a reason, there is a force, there is something that has created all of this, because it takes intelligence to do this. You know we are sitting here talking but this planet is going through space at a tremendous speed, it's turning over, and then it's circling around and it's not bumping headlong into any other planets, and it's been doing it for a long time. You see what I mean? And out of all the stars and planets in the universe that are working, things are working in harmony with each other. Because if not, things couldn't exist. But I feel that we are learning who we are and why we are. And as we get to that point, then we begin to do what we are here to do, to help everything to work together better. You know I think we've been put here to improve everything on this planet, like caretakers, or whatever we can do, whether we're doing it through music or whatever we're doing, if we're helping to add some meaning to other people's lives. Like in music a lot of times people are going through a lot of things in their life, a lot of tension, you know, a lot of things they're uptight about, they go to a musical concert and this helps to, that moment in their life becomes a beautiful moment. And it gives them incentive to go for another day. You know I've had people say well thank you so much for that. Because we have to have something to take us to that next moment. And when people don't have anything to take them to their next moment, they think about suicide or they drink or whatever. Because that inspiration, that incentive, to live to the next moment, isn't there. So we need to stay inspired, to have a goal, to believe that we can achieve that goal, and to believe that there is help outside, from another source other than ourselves. Because there are so many things that we don't

have the ability to deal with. Like you might, in a storm or in an earthquake or whatever, even in earthquakes and storms there are people who survive and people who live, who get through it. And even people maybe who are in the river getting ready to jump, somebody jumps in and saves them, or whatever. There is a system, and when we go through a day, we get up and go back to bed, whether we know it or not, we've had assistance in being able to get through that day without something tragic happening. You see what I mean? So I feel that there is a source that can assist us, and the more that we are able to connect with it, a lot of times we avoid paying a lot of dues or we avoid getting into problematic areas. Not that doesn't solve everything because there are still, I believe in life there is yin and yang. There is drama in everybody's life. So there are moments that we'd rather not have, or you know, that can be disappointing or maybe there may be moments when cash flow is short or there may be moments when we don't feel well. But we have to, at those moments, have to be able to go through those moments and stay centered and have that determination to get over this. And so that we can get back to that point where we're feeling good and we're feeling energetic and inspired, and then we can go out and work on a plan. And so it's important to have those kind of inner feelings. And I think that's part of the spirit. And when we see that and realize that somethingness is in us, however we want to relate to it, it's there. If we can communicate with it and feel that we can get assistance. Because there is times that we need, well everyday in our life we need to find out what we need to do. What's the best thing to do. When we get up in the morning, should I brush my teeth first or should I make this call first or should I go down — you've got ten things that's important so we have to prioritize. So if we have that inner incentive and knowledge we can do that. And if we believe well okay, I have an affirmation that I do. I feel that I say that I believe things are working out beneficial for me, you know, and that the things that I need are coming to me. And that I ask to gain understanding and wisdom to be able to find out how to get the knowledge. But at the same time I'm trying to be the best that I can be, and to each experience help me to be a positive person in whatever activity I'm in, whether it's playing music or maybe giving somebody information on the street, how to get to someplace where they're going. We have these opportunities each day to do this.

MR: Terrific. Oh, could we chat for a moment about your big band experience? Because I know you were with Hampton —

HO: Oh yeah, Hampton and Duke Ellington and Count Basie. It was a wonderful experience for me because I got a chance to be around and to play with musicians who I had great admiration for. To be able to see the level on how they function, and what the important things were. And I remember, now when I first got with Count Basie, it was here up in the Westchester area. And we were playing, I forget the venue. But we had went into —

prior to that time – into the store, you know, to buy some snacks or whatever we wanted before hit time, and I guess maybe we had an hour or so before we hit. And I just was, I kind of lost track of time, and I'm just looking for things. And I look up and nobody's in the store, all the musicians are gone. Nobody said to me listen it's time to hit. And I went to look at my watch and I'm running to get in, and when I get in the club everybody's on the bandstand and Basie's getting ready to hit. I had the stuff, and so from that moment on I made sure that I knew what the schedules were. But I found out that you have to be aware of certain things. You have to always be prepared, being on time, knowing, just preparation is a very important part of it. And of course Basie was a wonderful person. You know everybody loved him and respected him, and they used to call him "Chief." And so it was great experience, and when Duke Ellington, I was taking Paul Gonsalves' chair, because he had some gigs he was doing, so I did I guess about four or five performances in the Boston area. And Lionel Hampton, I worked with him here in Chicago. This was the time we had the blackout here in New York and Lindsay was —

MR: The mayor at that time.

HO: Was the mayor at that time. And the bus was on strike, the taxis were on strike, the subway. I had to walk from 95th Street all the way down to 31st Street. We were working in a club in a building down there. And then I worked other jobs around New York City with him. So that was a great experience. We had a lot of wonderful musicians in that band, George Coleman, the other saxophonist, and me. But they had a lot — it was a good experience, wonderful. You note one thing, you begin to — that's another level on the business because you're playing in venues that you don't get a chance to be in when you're trying to get to places. You know it's the top level basically. Carol Burnett had a party out in California that the band was invited to. So everywhere that Basie went it was a top place. Same way with Lionel. So you get to experience that and meet people and just see what that setting is about. And it's a wonderful experience.

MR: And gosh, you made quite a bit of music with Jack McDuff.

HO: Oh yeah. Jack and I met in Chicago because he lived there at the time. And he had a small band that we used to work with and rehearse. So that was my first time playing with Jack. And then when I came to New York and Jack came through I was affiliated with a gentleman named Lew Futterman that had a publishing company. So he would record a lot of the songs in the publishing company. And so McDuff recorded about three or four songs of mine, and then I recorded some other music. I had quite a few other songs that got recorded at that time.

MR: Yeah, you've done quite a bit of writing. Do you sit at a keyboard when you write? Or how does it evolve?

HO: No, I write from a horn. I'll hear a song and when I hear it, if I feel good or get that feeling about it then I go to my horn and play it and then put it on tape so I don't forget it. And then just kind of develop it from that point. Because a lot of times a song will just keep coming back to me, you know, and so I may write it and it may take me maybe, instead of writing it in one day or one sitting it is from time to time and I get little pieces here and then I get the completeness of the song. And then if it's a song I think it'd be nice to have a lyric to this. Then I start working on a lyric for it. But that's just basically how I write.

MR: Has it ever happened where the lyric comes first for you?

HO: No I always write instrumentally first. Yeah because I don't really consider myself a lyricist. But I've tried to do this because I want to get my songs done by vocalists as well so it's good to have a lyric.

MR: Yeah. Another iron in the fire.

HO: Yeah, yeah. Now on "Return of the Prodigal Son" I had several recordings on. Freddie Hubbard did it, George Benson did it. I was working with Ray Bryant at the time at Minton's as a matter of fact and he was getting ready to do some recordings so I wrote it for that particular recording. But Stanley Turrentine did it. So I had about seven or eight recordings on it.

MR: Neat. And I see you have some cable T.V. ventures?

HO: Yeah. On Manhattan Neighborhood Network. I produce shows here in Manhattan on West 59th Street and then I have a show out in Queens. And out there I have to play it on 3/4 tapes, so we have a dubbing system in the studio and I get an appointment to make dubs and I can bump it up to 3/4 and play it there, then I also have a show in Brooklyn, and so I have the three shows. And the one in Manhattan comes on every other Sunday, the one in Queens comes on every Sunday and every Saturday in Brooklyn. It's on public access. But it gives me a chance to share with the public things that I'm doing. And then other artists. Because a lot of times people will go see artists — for instance I had not too long ago Monty Alexander on my show. Now a lot of people might go see Monty, but they might not have an opportunity to hear him talk, other from announcing the tunes. And so doing interviews gives me an opportunity to do interviews with artists, say like Randy Weston, that people may go to hear but don't get a chance to hear what they feel and what they think and what's important to them. So I do interviews and then sometimes I interview performances and then a lot of times it gives me an opportunity to play videos that I've done so people can see what I'm doing instrumentally and musically. Because at the same time I'm trying to promote things that I'm doing as well, but also expose the audience to people that they know, people that they may not know but they should know. So that's the whole purpose of it.

MR: And I can see you have an interest in education too.

HO: Oh yeah.

MR: Even with the little ones.

HO: Yes, yes. Because I've learned so much from them. A lot of times people think children don't know very much, but children know a lot, even starting from two. Mine — like in the schools, when they've graduated from a school now, they would be ages of six, but they got diplomas, for engineering, diploma for being — you know because what you see there, even playing in kindergarten, here is a child that has a potential for building blocks, or here is somebody they see two other children fighting and they come and make peace. So there you see potential there. If it's worked on they can develop this. So they get a diploma for that. And they have their little caps and gowns. And we sing the songs you know. But I began to realize their capacities when we would start doing music. Because usually the way I would start off I would take the saxophone, I'd take it loose and show them the different parts. This is the reed, it's spelled R-E-E-D, and we'd have a little card so they're learning how to spell the words, they are learning the part of the saxophone, and the mouthpiece, the ligature and then we had cards for all of these. Sometimes I hide it behind my back and I say, "what is this again?" So it's like a game you know. So we have a lot of fun together. Then I put it together. Then I say, "this is what it sounds like," and I put it together and then I would start a song, and then I'd have them sing the song or play notes on a scale, and I'd say, "now repeat the notes, I want you to do it with the saxophone." So it would develop into a whole thing. At the same time they are listening, they are using their skills to remember, they are beginning to repeat what they hear, so this is developing these potentials that they have. And so you know we have a wonderful time, and the academic part of it learning how to spell the words.

MR: That's great.

HO: So it's great.

MR: Well this has been really a great, interesting conversation for me.

HO: I have to apologize. Sometimes you know I get caught up in —

MR: Well we may have to do Part Two down the line, because you have so much to say and so much in your career. And I appreciate your coming today.

HO: Oh I appreciate your inviting me.

MR: It's been very interesting, I'm so glad we kind of bumped into each other last night. Well best of luck with all the things on your plate and the irons in the fire.

HO: Okay. Thank you very much.

MR: And I hope to get to hear you play sometime.

HO: Yeah. How often are you in New York?

MR: Not often enough.

HO: Well I want to do some traveling, so maybe I can get up your way.

MR: Maybe we can have you up there.

HO: Yeah. So I've got a new CD out.

MR: Terrific.

HO: So I hope this opens the door.

MR: Okay. Thank you so much.

HO: Okay. Thank you.